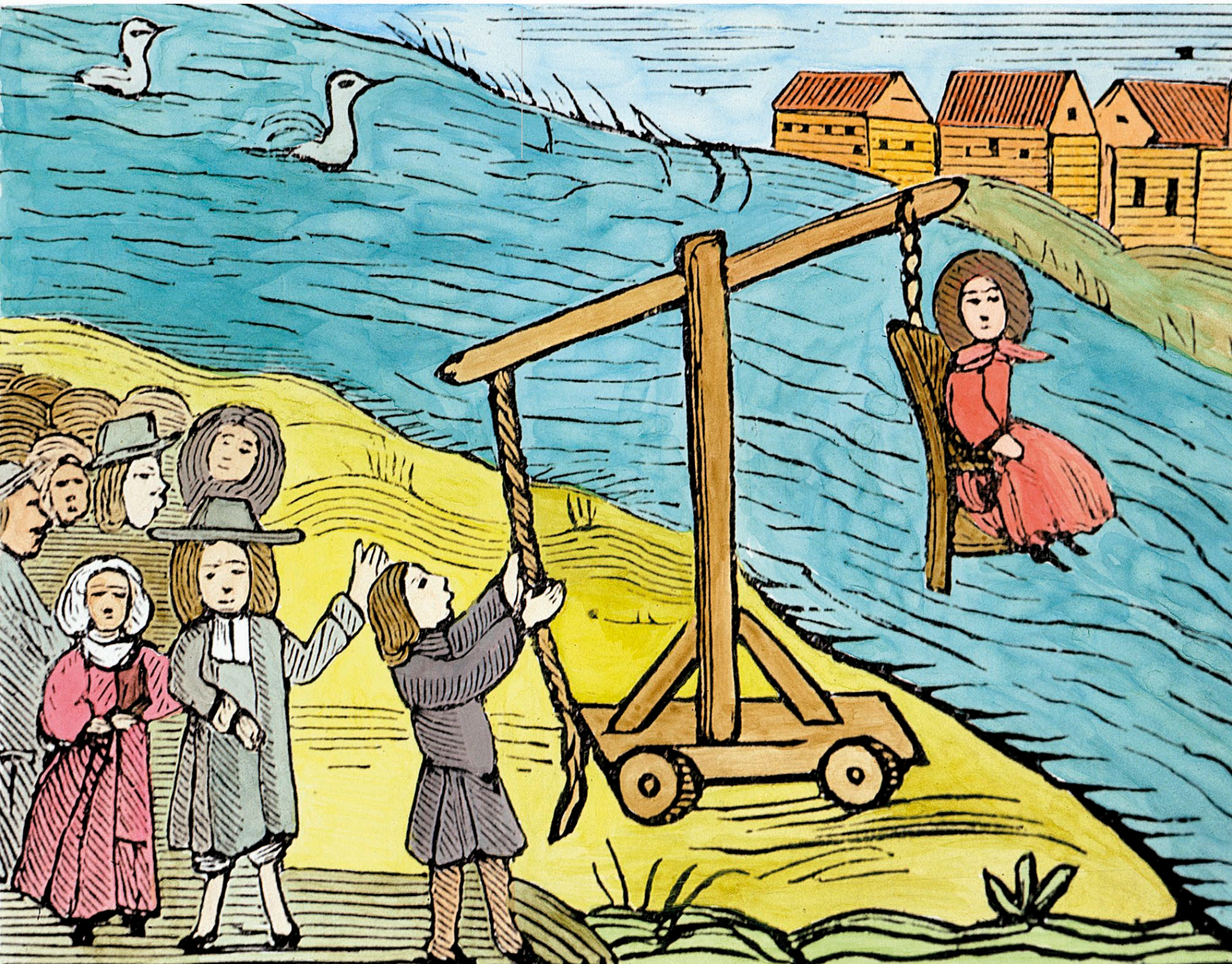




200 alleged witches between 1560 and 1660, while England and France each put around 500 to death. There were also significant numbers of cases in Scandinavia, the Netherlands, and Poland, yet in largely Catholic Southern Europe executions for witchcraft were rare. Then, just as the witch trials abated in Europe, the craze spread to the Americas.

Witch trials typically followed a pattern. The interrogation stage often yielded more suspects, as the accused tried to save herself by claiming others had inducted her. As a result, the bulk of trials occurred in clusters, such as the Trier trials (1581–1593), the Pendle trials in Lancashire (1612), and the Torsåker trials in Sweden (1675), during which

▲ Ducking ordeal

The ducking stool was used to identify witches. As water was reputed to repel a witch, an innocent woman would sink (and possibly drown), but a guilty one would float (and survive to be tried).